

# THE EXPENSIVE LESSONS FIELD DECK

Each one cost somebody a project, a client, or a career. Each card carries what it cost, the exact words of the person who paid it, and the move to make next time. Grouped by the situation you are in, not by theme.

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01 / THE PAPER TRAIL • BEFORE YOU HIT SEND

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01

SUPERS

PMS

EP 045

**Every email you send is a potential Exhibit 12. State facts, never opinions or conclusions.**

A 25-year-old PM's five emails asking 'are we still using the bad stuff?' ended up on a courtroom projector in a \$30 million dispute.

GARRETT MOTT • CONSTRUCTION TRIAL LAWYER, HENNIGH  
LAW • [HEAR IT →](#)

**Daily logs written the same day are admissible gold.  
Documentation created after a dispute starts has almost no  
credibility.**

Courts admit routine contemporaneous records under the business records exception. One super's meticulous logs caught a sub's invoice fraud and ended it with a letter.

GARRETT MOTT • CONSTRUCTION TRIAL LAWYER, HENNIGH  
LAW • [HEAR IT →](#)

## If you send the problem email to 25 people, nobody owns it. Name one person or it will not get done.

When Wes Juergens came back on the show after moving up to a regional superintendent role, he zeroed in on why very large projects sink: communication. On a smaller job a PM or PE covers seven or eight scopes and overhears everything in the trailer, but on a hundred person team each engineer owns a single scope, so the concrete engineer has no idea what the elevator guy or the window guy is doing. Wes borrows a saying from an experienced friend in the industry: if everybody's got it, nobody's got it. An email to two people gets handled because one of them makes sure it happens, while the same email to 25 people dies because everyone assumes somebody else is on it. His fix is written role expectations set early, so every problem lands on a name.

"If everybody's got it, then nobody's got it. If I send that email out to 25 people and say, hey, this is a big problem, they all just assume that somebody else is doing it."

WES JUERGENS · 26:29

**THE MOVE** Assign the problem to one named person with a deadline, then inform the wider group. Put written role expectations in place at kickoff so every scope has a single owner.

WES JUERGENS · REGIONAL SUPERINTENDENT · [HEAR IT AT 26:29 →](#)

## Zero RFIs on a project is a red flag that nobody asked the right questions, not a win to brag about.

Alex Belkofer runs VDC for McCarthy Building Companies, where the return on digital work gets framed as the cost of goals not scored, his goalie analogy for the 70 or 80 saves in a big game that nobody counts because the team kept winning. McCarthy pulls the risk curve forward into the design phase, blocking and tackling issues digitally so they never become RFIs in the field. He has seen projects brag about delivering zero RFIs, and he pushes back: a silent log usually means the team never verified its line of sight to the risk profile before field execution. The healthy signal is streamlined, higher quality RFIs with faster answers, not a low count.

"There's projects that are out there that say we've had zero RFIs. I would challenge and question though, is it good that there are no RFIs?"

ALEX BELKOFER · 20:32

**THE MOVE** Audit the RFI log for quality, not quantity. If a scope produced zero RFIs, ask whether the team actually had line of sight to its risk profile with the digital tools before field execution, and treat silence as unexamined risk.

ALEX BELKOFER · SENIOR DIRECTOR OF VDC, MCCARTHY  
BUILDING COMPANIES · [HEAR IT AT 20:32 →](#)

## You cannot fix a bad buy. Scope missed at buyout comes straight out of margin with no way to recover it.

Charles Ma, a structural engineer turned bootstrapped founder, chose Scoreboard AI's first workflow after discovery interviews with builders kept returning the same line: you can't fix a bad buy. Buyout is where the budget is set, and the operations team gets only a couple of weeks to write subcontracts, manually pulling scope inclusions out of thousands of pages of unstructured plans and specs. Anything missed in that window is never repriced; it comes directly out of profit margin later in the job. Stuff slips through the cracks until the last responsible moment, then blows up as a fire drill, which is why his tool scans the documents and pulls job specific scope inclusions for every trade.

"What we heard over and over again was you can't fix a bad buy. Scope buyout, that's where the budget is set. If you miss something, if you don't price it in during buyout, it comes directly out of your profit margin later on."

CHARLES MA · 14:29

**THE MOVE** Treat the buyout window as the most expensive few weeks on the job. Before subcontracts are signed, walk every bid package against the plans and specs for job specific scope inclusions, and put experienced eyes on what the estimate's first pass missed.

CHARLES MA · FOUNDER AND CEO, SCOREBOARD AI · [HEAR IT AT 14:29 →](#)

## Forty-five checklists completed within two minutes of each other is a pencil-whipping signature the data will expose later.

Tim Smith's owner-side commissioning team at QTS lives in the field, capped at 30 minutes a day in the site office, and one of the things they hunt is whether Level 2 arrival inspections actually happened. The tell is right in the commissioning platform: open CxAlloy and find 45 checklists all completed within two minutes of each other. When Level 2 gets pencil-whipped, the failures surface later as holdups in Level 3 and then Level 4 testing. Tim finds it is almost never malice, just a lack of education about why the checklist matters, so the response is mentoring rather than punishment, and catching it early actually aids the schedule.

"Did you actually do it, or did you just pencil whip the checklist? Can we go in and look at CxAlloy and see forty-five checklists that were all done within two minutes of each other?"

TIM SMITH · 35:52

**THE MOVE** Audit checklist completion timestamps every week and flag batches closed minutes apart. Respond by mentoring the crew on why the inspection matters downstream, not by writing them up.

TIM SMITH · DIRECTOR OF COMMISSIONING, QTS DATA CENTERS · [HEAR IT AT 35:52 →](#)

## Hit only 25 percent of critical path milestones for eight straight months and you have forfeited any claim to a time extension.

On a \$200M project where Joe Wilson's team supported the owner's rep, the scheduling data showed the contractor hitting only about 25 percent of critical path milestones on time. The contractor kept saying they would be fine, month after month, until they finally admitted to a month of delay just three months before completion. By then the one-month pattern had stretched to eight months of consistent underperformance, and the data itself had built the owner's case: the contractor had forfeited any entitlement to a time extension. The pattern, not any single missed date, was what closed the door.

"When one month pattern turns into three, that turns into eight months of basically not improving. Now all of a sudden you've built up a case where, okay guys, you're not entitled to any kind of extra time here."

JOE WILSON

**THE MOVE** Track your critical path hit rate every month and confront a slipping pattern within the first month or two. Never let a string of reassurances run long enough to become the owner's case against you.

JOE WILSON • FOUNDER AND CEO, PROJEXION • [HEAR IT →](#)

## 02

SUPERS

PMS

EXECS & OWNERS

EP 054

**Lead with the answer. 'This part is behind because of X, here is what we do about it.' Then earn the Gantt chart.**

Most project updates are structured like a murder mystery building to a reveal. Owners want the headline first; the detail comes only when someone asks.

LIBBY MAGLIOLO · FOUNDER, THE SLIDE MASTER · [HEAR IT →](#)



## Help the electrician solve the problem on site today and he will not hit you with a change order tomorrow.

Steve Little, who directs facilities and engineering for The Fresh Market, was walking a store job the week of the recording and found the electrician's work was not quite per the plans. Instead of forcing a rip-out, he walked it with the electrician and suggested an alternate route that got closer to the plan and still met its intent, and the electrician was over the moon because he did not have to tear out what he had built. Steve's bet is on reciprocity: if he later asks that same electrician for one more outlet tapped off the nearby circuit, no change order is coming. For him that is what a real trade partnership looks like, interpersonal credit built one solved problem at a time.

"I guarantee you, if I asked him, hey man, I need to make one more outlet right over here, you can tap off of this, you think he'd hit me with a change order after I just helped him?"

STEVE LITTLE · 35:17

**THE MOVE** When a trade's work drifts from the plans, walk it with them in person and find the fix that avoids rip-out before reaching for the contract. Bank the goodwill and spend it on the small asks later.

STEVE LITTLE · DIRECTOR OF FACILITIES AND  
ENGINEERING, THE FRESH MARKET · [HEAR IT AT 35:17 →](#)

**Raw data handed to a decision maker is not help. It is work you were supposed to do and pushed onto them.**

Saying 'twelve percent over budget due to this reason' is the job. The spreadsheet is not.

LIBBY MAGLIOLO • FOUNDER, THE SLIDE MASTER • [HEAR IT →](#)

## Pricing preconstruction too cheap can lose you the job. One owner rejected a GC for exactly that reason.

Jeremy Crumley, Preconstruction Director at Balfour Beatty, watched his team lose a pursuit for a reason that would have been unthinkable a decade ago: the owner told them their preconstruction services were priced too cheaply. The market has shifted, and owners increasingly read the precon fee as a signal of how much effort and value they are buying rather than expecting it as a free loss leader. Being the cheapest number on that line signaled the least effort, and it cost the firm the job. The lesson runs against every instinct to buy work with free precon.

"We were actually not awarded a project because the owner told us they thought our pre-construction services were too cheap."

JEREMY CRUMLEY

**THE MOVE** Price preconstruction to reflect the actual effort and value of the work, and present it as a professional service. A real precon fee wins jobs that a free line item loses.

JEREMY CRUMLEY • PRECONSTRUCTION DIRECTOR, BALFOUR BEATTY • [HEAR IT →](#)

## On the owner side you do not call the shots. You ask leading questions until the GC arrives at the solution itself.

Tim Straub started as a superintendent at Whiting-Turner building data centers, then crossed to the owner side as a Senior Technical Program Manager at Google responsible for construction quality and commissioning. The move taught him that the presumption that owners call the shots is a fallacy: on the owner side you lead through influence, asking leading questions that help the GC arrive at the solution itself rather than prescribing it. That takes respecting that other GCs win with different means and methods than the ones he grew up with, and adapting his approach to the distinct cultures of iron workers, electricians, and GC teams. Command-and-control from the owner's chair simply does not get the work done.

**THE MOVE** When you sit on the owner side, drop the directive. Ask leading questions until the contractor arrives at the solution themselves, and respect their means and methods once they do.

TIM STRAUB • SENIOR TECHNICAL PROGRAM MANAGER,  
GOOGLE • [HEAR IT →](#)

## Walk the constructability with the foreman face to face. A short email is where a generation hides from hard conversations.

Steve Little and the hosts dug into what got lost when construction management moved behind screens, and Stephen admitted he had lived it himself, more comfortable in BIM 360 and Last Planner views than walking with the foreman challenging constructability ideas. Steve's diagnosis is that technology has become a buffer that gives people a safe space to be on the job without interacting with it, because challenging somebody in person is genuinely harder than firing off a short email. He contrasts it with the old OAC discipline of running the logs and driving the schedule face to face, and with the real relationships built by getting bloodied up together on site. The jobsite walk with the electrician that same week was his proof of what the in-person version still buys you.

"It's a whole lot more difficult to challenge somebody face to face than it is over a short email."

STEVE LITTLE · 33:57

**THE MOVE** Take constructability challenges to the foreman in person and keep email for documenting what was agreed. If the conversation could change the outcome, have it face to face on the walk.

STEVE LITTLE · DIRECTOR OF FACILITIES AND  
ENGINEERING, THE FRESH MARKET · [HEAR IT AT 33:57 →](#)

## 11

EXECS &amp; OWNERS

EP 024

## An owner who can explain exactly what changed after a fatality may be safer than a contractor with a clean record.

David Tibbetts, Chief Safety Officer at Highwire, points to an uncomfortable gap: recordable injury rates have dropped 80 percent in 30 years, yet construction fatalities have sat near 1,000 a year with no discernible decrease for 15 to 20 years. That is why Highwire weights EMR at just 10 percent of its prequalification score and treats no single data point, not a fatality history, not an OSHA citation, as an automatic disqualifier. A contractor who had a fatality and can clearly articulate what happened, what was learned, and what systems changed may have a more mature safety culture than one whose clean recordable rate is masking unaddressed exposures. The risk signal's job is to start that conversation, not end it.

"There is no result of a prequalification assessment... that should automatically disqualify a contractor. It is a risk insight."

DAVID TIBBETTS

**THE MOVE** When a prequalification flag appears, schedule the conversation instead of pulling the trigger: ask what happened, what the company learned, and what changed, and weigh the quality of that answer more than the flag itself.

DAVID TIBBETTS • CHIEF SAFETY OFFICER, HIGHWIRE •  
[HEAR IT →](#)

## **The skills flip at general superintendent. Senior super is 80 percent technical; general super is 80 percent soft skills.**

The skills that got you promoted are nearly the inverse of what the next job needs. The job becomes guiding the collective mass of trades, not directing.

MITCH MCDONALD • GENERAL SUPERINTENDENT, XL  
CONSTRUCTION • [HEAR IT →](#)

## **Before blaming a worker's choice, prove the work was planned, the equipment was there, and the training and time existed.**

David Tibbetts of Highwire insists that root cause analysis exhaust every systemic failure before anyone reaches for personal choice as the explanation. The questions come in order: did we plan the work effectively, did we set the worker up for success, did they have the equipment, the time, and the training. His working group's data shows why the discipline matters, finding four times as many serious-injury-potential exposures as recordable incidents across participating projects, most of them untracked. Jumping to blame closes the investigation exactly where the fatal patterns live, and only after the systemic questions are answered honestly can an individual factor even enter the conversation.

"Only after we've convinced ourselves of all those things can we start to even think about an individual factor like a personal choice."

DAVID TIBBETTS

**THE MOVE** In every incident review, work the systemic checklist first: planning, equipment, time, and training. Do not allow personal choice into the conversation until every one of those has been honestly cleared.

DAVID TIBBETTS • CHIEF SAFETY OFFICER, HIGHWIRE •  
[\*\*HEAR IT →\*\*](#)



## If you are not doing concrete lift drawings and MEP coordination before a pour, you are leaving risk on a 16-hour activity you cannot undo.

Jack Desloge came out of McCarthy's field operations before becoming a Senior VDC Manager at VIA Technik, and he calls concrete planning VDC's highest-leverage low-hanging fruit. Nothing moves a job faster than a concrete pour and nothing is harder to fix afterward: it is a high-dollar activity that happens in about 16 hours and cannot be undone. Lift drawings plus MEP coordination before the pour de-risk exactly that moment, catching embeds, sleeves, and conflicts while they are still lines on a drawing instead of problems in cured concrete. Skipping that work leaves an outsized pile of risk sitting on the schedule's fastest-moving activity.

"If you're not doing some aspect of concrete planning and concrete lift drawing development... you're leaving a lot of risk on the table for an activity that happens in 16 hours."

JACK DESLOGE

**THE MOVE** Make concrete lift drawings and pre-pour MEP coordination standard scope on every job, and aim your VDC hours at the pour before any other workflow.

JACK DESLOGE • SR. VDC MANAGER, VIATECHNIK • [HEAR IT →](#)

## If the GC super walks the site with his harness strap undone, every trade will too. Injuries trace back to the example you set.

As a regional superintendent dropped into troubled jobs, Wes Juergens starts with culture, and he ties injuries and quality escapes directly back to the GC's own example. If the superintendent walks the site with his harness straps undone, his vest unzipped, and his safety glasses swinging from his hand, every trade reads that as the real standard, the same way un-pre-punched GC inspection requests tell trade partners quality does not matter. His favorite proof it can work the other way: a laborer with a shovel turned around and told Wes to put his gloves on, while Wes's own people stared in disbelief. Wes thanked him on the spot and recognized him at the next all-hands safety meeting, because a crew unafraid to call out the boss is the goal state.

"If the superintendent's walking around and his straps undone and his vest is unzipped and swinging his safety glasses in his hands, you're setting the example right there."

WES JUERGENS · 14:12

**THE MOVE** Wear every piece of PPE correctly yourself and pre-punch your own areas before calling inspections. When a craft worker calls out a leader on safety, thank them publicly at the next site meeting.

WES JUERGENS · REGIONAL SUPERINTENDENT · [HEAR IT AT 14:12 →](#)

## Running 400 adults at 6am as a dictatorship will fail. People only listen when they are part of the conversation.

Chris Masse runs daily coordination for hundreds of workers as a senior superintendent at EllisDon, getting roughly 400 adults moving in the same direction at 6am. His conclusion is that dictatorship fails at that scale: people listen when they are part of the conversation and tune out when they are treated as subordinates receiving orders. Construction culture still rewards command-and-control, and the industry talks constantly about being in control while rarely talking about being an incredible teammate, which Masse and his coach Tim Smith argue is the more effective posture. The daily huddle works because the crews help shape the plan they are about to execute.

"People will listen when they're part of the conversation, but if it's going to be a dictatorship, I think you're going to fail."

CHRIS MASSE

**THE MOVE** Run morning coordination as a conversation, not a briefing. Give crews a real voice in shaping the day's plan so they execute a plan they helped build.

CHRIS MASSE • SENIOR SUPERINTENDENT, ELLISDON •

[HEAR IT →](#)

## It is not the guy in the trailer that builds the job. Make young PMs lay block and walk steel so they respect the craft.

At Barton Malow, Rener co-created a program called Building Skills that sent young project managers to school for a day, once a month or every other month across the 16 CSI divisions, to physically do the trade work. One engineer proudly took an hour to lay a single perfect block and was told you cannot lay one block an hour; others placed yards of concrete, framed small sheds, and walked steel at the ironworkers training center. The point was humility, understanding why a plasterer with 20 years of experience makes the work look effortless. A degree does not put the work in place, and without genuine appreciation for the trades it just gets you chased back into the trailer.

"We want you to appreciate what these tradespeople do, and it takes a while to get good at what they do. If not for them, the jobs don't get built. It's not the guy in the trailer that builds the job."

ANDREW RENER · 12:28

**THE MOVE** Put young PMs and estimators through real trade work, laying block, placing concrete, walking steel, early in their careers, so they manage from respect for the craft instead of a title in the trailer.

ANDREW RENER · EXECUTIVE, ARCHITECTURAL METALS ·

[HEAR IT AT 12:28 →](#)

## 09

SUPERS

PMS

EP 055

**Write the commissioning schedule assuming it will be cut, because every week and dollar lost upstream gets taken from the end.**

Tim Smith has spent more than 30 years commissioning power plants from Kuwait and Saudi Arabia to Oklahoma City and Boston, and now directs commissioning for QTS Data Centers. In all that time, commissioning has been the project's relief valve: lose two weeks on the base build, pull it from commissioning; lose a million dollars of budget, pull it from commissioning. By the time actual startup arrives, the team is a dollar late and a day short. So he writes every commissioning schedule assuming shortfalls, because the bid-format version never survives. The data center boom has only amplified the squeeze, making it a struggle to commission at the quality the end users expect.

"We lost two weeks on the base build, let's pull it from commissioning. We lost a million dollars on budget, let's pull it from commissioning. So by the time you get to actual startup, you're a dollar late and a day short."

TIM SMITH • 4:08

**THE MOVE** Build the project schedule backwards from the drop dead turnover date with every commissioning step in it, and let that force changes to the build schedule. Write the commissioning plan assuming shortfalls will land on it.

TIM SMITH • DIRECTOR OF COMMISSIONING, QTS DATA CENTERS • [HEAR IT AT 4:08 →](#)

## Missed submittal dates are the earliest reliable warning of schedule delay. Track them before you track anything else.

Joe Wilson built a spreadsheet-based risk analytics tool during COVID for a \$100M project that was going poorly, and that work became his company, which builds data foundations for contractors. Across the projects he analyzes, submittal adherence is the single best leading indicator of schedule risk: teams that miss submittal due dates go on to incur schedule delays. The problem is that the system-of-record workflow for updating submittals runs one item at a time, and in an industry that values speed, teams default to Excel the moment the system is slower than they need it to be. That fragmentation destroys the very indicator that would have warned them, and makes portfolio-level analytics nearly impossible.

"Submittals are one of the key early indicators of a project at risk. If you're missing your dates and your submittals, it's likely that you will be incurring delays on your schedule."

JOE WILSON

**THE MOVE** Track submittal date adherence in the system of record from day one and report it before any other metric. Fix whatever workflow friction is pushing your team to Excel, because the indicator dies with the fragmentation.

JOE WILSON • FOUNDER AND CEO, PROJEXION • [HEAR IT →](#)

## Put model due, signed off, shop drawings in, and approved for install in the field schedule and track them like a bottom-out date.

Wally Castro, a superintendent at Bernards who started at Turner, answered the question of what VDC misses with one word: schedule. His current City of Ontario job was sold as an eight week coordination cycle on a three story building, so he demands per level dates from the VDC team: model due, model signed off, shop drawings in, shop drawings approved and ready for install. He wants every one of those dates living in his field schedule so that when something slips he captures the movement and can see whether it is detrimental to installation, and he makes his drop dead dates known early. He has watched design build jobs where the design catches the construction and the job ends up totally shot, costing the owner money instead of saving it, with no way to recover.

"This day level one will be due. This day level one will be signed off. This day level one shop drawings will be in. This day level one shop drawings will be approved and ready for install. I want all those days in my schedule."

WALLY CASTRO · 22:10

**THE MOVE** Load every VDC milestone, model due, signed off, shop drawings in, approved for install, into the master field schedule by level, and track them weekly like pour dates with drop dead dates communicated up front.

WALLY CASTRO · SUPERINTENDENT, BERNARDS · [HEAR IT AT 22:10 →](#)

## The schedule is the plan. Perfect RFIs and submittals cannot save a job where nobody trusts or is aligned to it.

Franco Giaquinto built the scheduling startup Ipsum in Chile and relaunched it in the US as Outbuild, having picked the space with his founder filter: find the biggest shit show in an industry and fix it. He argues the old scheduling tools promote unhealthy habits, terrible coordination, bad relationships between stakeholders, and no clear plan to get back on track, ending in claims and legal disputes that now involve more money and more time than ever. Nobody was supporting the field, where the reality of the project actually lives. His founding thesis is that perfect paperwork cannot compensate for a plan the team does not believe in or align to.

"You can have the best RFIs, the best submittals, the best everything, but if your plan is shit and no one is aligned, it's very hard to end up on the right track."

FRANCO GIAQUINTO · 5:12

**THE MOVE** Fix plan trust before buying any other PM tool: build one schedule the field, the trades, and the office all believe in and align to, and treat alignment to it as the leading indicator of project health.

FRANCO GIAQUINTO · CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, OUTBUILD ·

[HEAR IT AT 5:12 →](#)



# 05

PMS

EXECS & OWNERS

EP 053

## **Deliberately recruit your loudest known detractor into the pilot so objections surface before the enterprise rollout.**

Surface the objections early and fix them with the vendor while it is still cheap, rather than discovering them across 120 people later.

ELLIOT CHRISTIANSEN · SVP OPERATIONS, CLEVELAND  
CONSTRUCTION · [HEAR IT →](#)

## Never introduce a new tool and a new process in the same rollout. One is change management; both is a multi-year slog.

Aaron McClellan runs construction technology at Granite Construction, where every candidate solution goes through a build versus buy evaluation. Security comes first, with Granite's IT department running cybersecurity analysis because the company does federal work. Then the team evaluates the process itself and matches the solution to the existing process, specifically so they do not have to go through massive change management. A new technology is already one piece of change management on its own; introduce a new technology and change the process at the same time and you are talking about a very long adoption. The guiding question is whether they can get the tool to operations as fast as possible with as little change as necessary.

"If you introduce a new technology, that's already one piece of change management that has to happen. So if you start introducing a new technology and changing the process, you're talking a long time."

AARON MCCLELLAN · 9:45

**THE MOVE** Map the candidate tool against your existing process before you buy, and pick the option that changes only one variable. If the tool truly requires a new process, run the process change as its own separate rollout.

AARON MCCLELLAN · CONSTRUCTION TECHNOLOGY MANAGER,  
GRANITE CONSTRUCTION · [HEAR IT AT 9:45 →](#)

## **Distrust any vendor claim of hours saved per week. Those are hours 41 to 50, not the hours that matter.**

John Riggs, a Senior Project Manager at Suffolk, has grown numb to vendor marketing that promises hours saved per week, because the hours a tool saves are rarely the hours that matter on a jobsite. With project lifespans running two to four years, even piloting a product across 20 jobsites cannot produce real success metrics quickly, so claims about how many projects a tool has been used on and how well it worked deserve skepticism on their face. His warning to vendors is that overselling to get in the door guarantees disappointment on the job, and his own rule is that innovation should be judged on iteration, where five near-misses and a sixth-try success is the right aim.

"We saved you 10 hours a week on average. I don't know if you will. Those are probably hours 41 to 50. Or 61 to 70."

JOHN RIGGS

**THE MOVE** Ask every vendor how long and on how many completed projects their metrics were actually measured, and evaluate the tool on whether it removes the hours that matter, not the total it claims to save.

JOHN RIGGS • SENIOR PROJECT MANAGER, SUFFOLK • [HEAR IT →](#)

## **Require usage dashboards from every vendor, because people will tell you they use the tool when the data says zero.**

A superintendent claimed he had asked the Q&A tool twelve questions. The dashboard showed none. Accountability needs data, not self-report.

ELLIOT CHRISTIANSEN • SVP OPERATIONS, CLEVELAND  
CONSTRUCTION • [HEAR IT →](#)

## Do not bring in another point solution unless it eliminates two or three existing ones. Otherwise you just added a login.

Hannu Lindberg leads construction technology at DPR Construction in an industry littered with point solutions, each purpose built for one of the roughly 150 processes a project has to manage. Every added app is another place to administer information, another potential data bottleneck, and another application some poor superintendent has to log into. His filter at DPR, one his teams are probably tired of hearing, is that a new tool must eliminate two or three existing solutions and be more comprehensive and integrated. He even jokes that the real business idea is a fund that buys every point solution in a single workflow and simply makes them work together under one brand.

"Don't bring in just another point solution. Bring in something that's going to eliminate two or three other solutions. Find something that is more comprehensive, more integrated."

HANNU LINDBERG • 24:16

**THE MOVE** Before approving any new tool, name the two or three existing solutions it will retire. If it only adds another login, another data bottleneck, and another place to administer information, pass.

HANNU LINDBERG • TECHNOLOGY LEADER, DPR  
CONSTRUCTION • [HEAR IT AT 24:16 →](#)

## If your tool is harder than the hand signature it replaces, crews revert, and everybody in their network hears about it.

Jackie Guilbault has marketed construction tech at Topcon, Versatile, and Document Crunch, going as far as operating an excavator to understand her users. When co-host Lars described a government retirement process running on a three inch stack of hand signed paper in an underground vault and noted that it works, she pointed out the trap: if the promoted replacement is harder and takes weeks of training, users go straight back to the hand signature. In a relationship driven industry where everyone talks about their experiences, a tool that does not do what it says online is a credibility killer, and the whole network hears about it. That lost trust, she argues, is nearly impossible to win back.

"If the solution that's promoted to you is harder and takes weeks of training, then you'll revert back to that hand signature. If it doesn't do what it says online and it's actually harder, it's a credibility killer and everybody's gonna hear about it."

JACKIE GUILBAULT · 40:39

**THE MOVE** Before rollout, test the tool head to head against the manual process it replaces with real field users. If it needs weeks of training or is slower than the old way, fix that before launch, because reverting crews will tell their entire network.

JACKIE GUILBAULT · PRODUCT MARKETING MANAGER,  
DOCUMENT CRUNCH · [HEAR IT AT 40:39 →](#)

## Field tech does not save you months on the schedule. It gives you your time back and real data when a dispute lands.

Chris Masse, a senior superintendent at EllisDon, admits he was a late adopter still running jobs with Crayolas, highlighters, and 11 by 17s before a pilot project changed his mind. When co-host Lars asked whether the technology actually returns time, his answer was blunt: if you expect it to save months on the schedule, it will not, and that expectation sets you up for disappointment. What it gives back is his own personal time, plus real data when a conflict lands, laid out as you did this, I did this, here is the proof, so both sides come to an agreement and carry on. He figures it is 99 percent right and he will take that all day long.

"If you think it's going to save you months on the schedule, it's not. What it's giving me is my time back, and allowing me to present real data in the event of a conflict."

CHRIS MASSE · 23:28

**THE MOVE** Sell and measure field tech on the superintendent's personal time returned and on dispute ready records, not schedule compression. When a conflict lands, bring the laid out data, agree, and carry on.

CHRIS MASSE · SENIOR SUPERINTENDENT, ELLISDON ·

[HEAR IT AT 23:28 →](#)

## 06

PMS

EXECs &amp; OWNERS

EP 028

**Only automate a task that is both repetitive and annoying. If it is not annoying, let your people keep doing it.**

Sarah Buchner started as a carpenter at 12 and spent 15 years in the field before a fatality on her Berlin high-rise pushed her into construction software, where she founded Trunk Tools. Her triage rule for construction companies is a two-part test: only automate work that is both repetitive and annoying. If a task is not repetitive, AI will struggle to get good at it, and if it is not annoying, people actually enjoy doing it and should keep it. By her count roughly 80 percent of white-collar construction workflows fail the necessity test, but even there she designs agents like her submittal agent to do the bureaucratic 95 percent while leaving the final call to the human, because fully automating those steps means the industry forgets how to do them within five to ten years.

"If a task is repetitive and annoying, you should throw AI against it. Because if it's not repetitive, it's probably going to be hard to make an AI really good at it."

DR. SARAH BUCHNER

**THE MOVE** Run every automation candidate through the two-question filter: is it repetitive, and is it annoying. If it fails either test, leave it with your people, and when you do automate, keep the decision in human hands.

DR. SARAH BUCHNER • FOUNDER AND CEO, TRUNK TOOLS •  
[HEAR IT →](#)



## One retiring veteran takes five new hires to replace. The real labor shortage is knowledge leaving, not bodies missing.

Angelo Suntres, Director of Operations at Matina, an MEP contractor, argues the labor crisis is misdiagnosed: roughly 400,000 workers retire from the industry each year against about 100,000 apprentices completing programs, and of the 250,000 or so who start an apprenticeship only 30 to 35 percent finish. Worse, one experienced worker carries productivity it takes about five new entrants to replace, so the real gap is knowledge walking out the door, not empty seats. His conclusion is that finding bodies will not be the hard part; transferring knowledge into those bodies to make them useful will be. He is even building a mentorship matching and lessons learned tool himself, having systematized 372 items from his own field logbook.

"I don't think finding bodies is going to be an issue, but transferring the knowledge to put into those people to make them useful is going to be the real challenge."

ANGELO SUNTRES · 4:11

**THE MOVE** Plan for five new hires of productivity behind every retiring veteran, and start capturing their knowledge now: pair them with new entrants and get their lessons learned out of their heads and into a searchable system before they leave.

ANGELO SUNTRES · DIRECTOR OF OPERATIONS, MATINA ·  
[HEAR IT AT 4:11 →](#)

## The real AI risk is not security. It is someone shipping the first draft as the final draft.

Hugh Seaton, founder of The Link, has read plenty of corporate AI policies, and almost all of them obsess over security, which he calls the least of a contractor's worries. The bigger danger is the easy button: AI gives great demos, cannot answer concisely, and knows nothing about your specific job. It hands back a first draft of an answer, and people who ship that draft as the final product are the ones who get their companies in trouble. His prescription for GC leadership starts small: get your arms around the chatbots your people are already using and train them to prompt and to review.

"It doesn't know what's going on in your job. It doesn't have any judgment like a human would. It's going to give you a first draft of an answer, and if people treat that like a final draft, they're going to get in trouble."

HUGH SEATON · 9:38

**THE MOVE** Rewrite the AI policy around review, not just data security. Train teams on prompting, and make it a rule that every AI output is a first draft that gets human judgment applied before it goes out the door.

HUGH SEATON · FOUNDER, THE LINK · [HEAR IT AT 9:38 →](#)

## Do not automate the tasks that train your people. The PE walking the site with a camera is learning the job.

Michael Zeppieri, VP of Digital Solutions at Skanska USA, came up through West Point and Boeing, and he borrows a military insight: mundane, repetitive tasks build muscle memory. The project engineer walking the site with a camera is not just taking photos, they are learning the ebb and flow of the job, and a photo robot that takes over the walk removes exactly the development that was making that person better. His warning is that automating those tasks is an easy mistake because the ROI math never accounts for the training value. Which tasks get protected from automation has to be a deliberate decision, not a byproduct of whatever a vendor happens to sell.

"You can very easily make the mistake of automating the things that are actually making your people better."

MICHAEL ZEPPIERI

**THE MOVE** Before automating any task, ask what the person doing it is learning. Keep a deliberate list of developmental tasks you will protect even when a robot could do them cheaper.

MICHAEL ZEPPIERI • VP OF DIGITAL SOLUTIONS, SKANSKA USA • [HEAR IT →](#)

## When you try to automate a process you discover how much unpriced judgment the 'not that bright' guy was adding.

Hugh Seaton, founder of The Link and now an AI strategy consultant to contractors, pushes back on human in the loop as a throwaway phrase that usually means automate everything and stick an approval at the end. In his experience you cannot automate as much as you think, and the attempt is exactly what reveals how much unpriced judgment people add, including the guy nobody rates as bright. Pull those people out of the process and you do not just take a little pain later, you introduce brand new risk that nobody budgeted. His frame for leadership is to treat expertise as a strategic asset: figure out what it is, capture it, and elevate people rather than skim tasks.

"When you try to automate a thing, you realize how smart people are. Even the guy that you don't think is that bright is adding a ton of value in the process. If you pull people out of it, you introduce new risk."

HUGH SEATON · 9:36

**THE MOVE** Before automating any process, map the judgment the humans inside it are quietly adding and price the new risk of removing them. Capture and elevate that expertise instead of just deleting the headcount.

HUGH SEATON · FOUNDER, THE LINK · [HEAR IT AT 9:36 →](#)

## An LLM does not know it is wrong and wants to please you, so it will build your confidence on the wrong path.

Michael Zeppieri of Skanska USA, who came to construction from systems engineering at West Point and software at Boeing, names a specific operational hazard in the industry's rush to chat-based AI. An LLM does not know when it is wrong, and it is built to please you, so instead of correcting a flawed plan it reinforces it, building your confidence that you are on the right path. That turns the tool into a confirmation bias machine at exactly the moment you think you are checking your judgment. For anyone using a chatbot to pressure-test a construction decision, the agreeable answer is the one to distrust most.

"Not only does it not know it's wrong, it wants to please you, so it actually builds your confidence that you're on the right path... in many ways it's confirmation bias."

MICHAEL ZEPPIERI

**THE MOVE** Treat an LLM's agreement as a warning sign rather than validation. Force it to argue against your position, and verify any consequential call with a person who knows the work.

MICHAEL ZEPPIERI • VP OF DIGITAL SOLUTIONS, SKANSKA USA • [HEAR IT →](#)

## Experienced workers' knowledge is walking out the door and there are roughly five years left to capture it digitally.

Mark Fly's urgency about knowledge capture has nothing to do with the technology and everything to do with the retirement clock. He wants to reach boomers and veterans leaving the industry and give them ways to release their knowledge before it is gone, pairing that capture with mentorship for the young workers coming up. On the show he and Stephen sketched what it could look like, from digitizing a career into an AI twin of an expert like Mark himself to gamified scenario walkthroughs through the CSI divisions. His window is explicit: with the knowledge leaving the field now, the next five years are when it gets captured or lost.

"With the knowledge leaving the field, capturing that now for over the next five years is crucial."

MARK FLY · 46:50

**THE MOVE** Start structured capture with your retiring field veterans now: recorded scenario walkthroughs, mentorship pairings, and digitized decision knowledge, while they are still on the payroll.

MARK FLY · PRODUCT EVANGELIST AND CONSTRUCTION TECH ADVISOR · [HEAR IT AT 46:50 →](#)

03

SUPERS

PMS

EP 005

**The company will always do what is best for the company, so you must do what is best for you and your family.**

Mitch calls this realization the turning point in his relationship with his career. Never bleed for a company the way it will not bleed for you.

MITCH MCDONALD • GENERAL SUPERINTENDENT, XL  
CONSTRUCTION • [HEAR IT →](#)

## Finishing on schedule and budget only buys you the right to bid the next one. The career gets built in moments not in the contract.

Sean Johnson, founder of Madison Consulting Services, builds on The Discipline of Market Leaders: you can win on best product, on operational efficiency, or on customer intimacy, and only the third lane is open to everybody. Hitting schedule and budget is table stakes, the price of being allowed to bid the next one, while the owner who asks for you by name gets made in small moments that were never in the contract. His formative example is a hotel clerk who ran into town through a blizzard to buy the Diet Coke the front desk did not stock. He systematizes the idea with a champagne fridge labeled champagne is for closers, opening a bottle with every new client no matter the size.

"It's really hard to compete on best product and it's really hard to compete on operational efficiency. But everybody can do customer intimacy if they want to."

SEAN JOHNSON · 22:07

**THE MOVE** Build your own playbook of deliberate moments for owners and architects, a handwritten note, a celebration ritual, a weekly check in, and run it on every project instead of repeating one good gesture once and hoping schedule and budget do the rest.

SEAN JOHNSON · FOUNDER, MADISON CONSULTING SERVICES  
• [HEAR IT AT 22:07 →](#)



## Never burn a bridge in commercial construction. You will work with the same people again wearing different hard hats.

Wes Juergens has spent his career as a superintendent in Houston commercial construction, and his experience is that the fourth-largest city in the country operates like a small town. Crews, foremen, and managers cross paths again and again across projects and companies for decades, often on opposite sides of the table from where they last met. That reality turns bridge-burning from a momentary release into a career-limiting move, because the person you torch today will be back on your next job wearing a different color hard hat. His advice is to protect the relationship even when the job or the dispute goes sideways.

"Don't burn that bridge, dude, because we'll be back around soon. We might be wearing different color hard hats the next time we see each other."

WES JUERGENS

**THE MOVE** End every job, dispute, and departure with the relationship intact, and assume the person across the table will show up on your next project in a different role.

WES JUERGENS • SENIOR SUPERINTENDENT, AUSTIN  
COMMERCIAL • [HEAR IT →](#)

## Create value for the person two levels above you and advancement takes care of itself.

Aaron McClellan did 11 years in the Army, with the 82nd Airborne and then Special Forces at 5th Group, and came into construction on paper unexperienced and unqualified. What carried over was a single value rule: whatever you are doing in your current job, the value you contribute needs to reach the person sitting two levels above you, your boss's boss. He argues that if you have that mindset you will succeed in the industry, no doubt about it, and that companies cannot cap someone generating that much value. The alternative he warns against is staying what the military calls the gray man, floating in the middle, which is exactly where you will stay.

"Your value that you're contributing needs to attribute to the person that's sitting two levels above you. If you have that mindset, then you're gonna succeed in the industry, no doubt about it."

AARON MCCLELLAN · 43:50

**THE MOVE** Before you take on any piece of work, ask how it creates value for your boss's boss, then make that contribution visible to them. Do not settle into being the gray man in the middle.

AARON MCCLELLAN · CONSTRUCTION TECHNOLOGY MANAGER,  
GRANITE CONSTRUCTION · [HEAR IT AT 43:50 →](#)

## If you are doing the innovator's job right, today could be your last day. You cannot protect your job and ask hard questions.

After his run as Director of Innovation at Swinerton, Aaron Anderson concluded that the innovation role only works if risk tolerance, including the willingness to be fired, is written into the job description. Doing the job right means asking the hard questions that make an organization uncomfortable, and you cannot ask them while simultaneously protecting your seat. He pairs this with his diagnosis of epistemic distance: people trust their own intentions and nobody else's, so an innovator who plays it safe never earns the standing to show anyone a different way. He applies the same verdict to the whole industry, which quashes curiosity in the name of fundamentals and kills its next generation of innovators.

"I need to be willing and accept that if I'm doing my job right as an innovator, that this could be my last day. You can't protect your job and ask hard questions."

AARON ANDERSON

**THE MOVE** If you hold an innovation role, write risk tolerance into it explicitly, including your willingness to lose the job. Ask the hard question even when it threatens your seat, or admit you are not doing the work.

AARON ANDERSON • FORMER DIRECTOR OF INNOVATION,  
SWINERTON • [HEAR IT →](#)

# 04

EXECS & OWNERS

FOUNDERS

EP 041

## **Nobody builds 30 percent cheaper on a cost-plus contract. Adoption fails on incentives, not technology.**

Billing models reward hours, not outcomes, so a contractor has no reason to deploy efficiency tech that shrinks the billable base.

KP REDDY · MANAGING PARTNER, SHADOW VENTURES · [HEAR  
IT →](#)

## Three percent margin turned over twelve billing cycles is a thirty percent return on capital. Pitch against that, not the margin.

As former Director of Innovation at Swinerton, Aaron Anderson watched productivity software pitch itself against construction's famous 3 percent margin and miss the real economics. On a \$100M project a GC has roughly \$15M of working capital deployed, and that 3 percent margin turns over 8 to 12 billing cycles a year, which compounds to roughly a 30 percent return on capital. That return is the hurdle rate any new tool or business model actually has to clear, which is why he argues disrupting a GC takes something like \$100M of patient cash on a balance sheet, not an army of software engineers. Software aimed at shaving the 3 percent is aimed at the wrong number.

"We talk about low margins in construction at 3%. But your return on capital is freaking massive. It's 3% 12 times. That's effectively a 30% return on your cap."

AARON ANDERSON

**THE MOVE** Before pitching or buying any productivity tool, compute the project's return on capital from margin times billing cycles, and make the case against that hurdle rate instead of the margin line.

AARON ANDERSON • FORMER DIRECTOR OF INNOVATION,  
SWINERTON • [HEAR IT →](#)

## Tell the customer what your product will not do before they find out on a jobsite. Honesty outsells features.

Mark Fly went from swinging hammers to evangelizing SmartBid, and co-host Lars, then a contractor customer, remembered exactly why he trusted him: he was burned so many times by software salesmen promising features that never showed up. Mark's team held the line from marketing through sales, refusing the pitch language entirely; he says if he hears the phrase game changer one more time he will throw up. After telling a prospect what the product did for their job, the evangelist in him would also tell them what it would not do. In an industry where decades of overpromising put workers' shields permanently up, that stated honesty was the thing that kept customers like Lars for nearly 20 years.

"The evangelist part of me would tell them, and it also will not do this or this or this."

MARK FLY · 20:49

**THE MOVE** Open the demo with what the product does for the buyer's specific pain, then state plainly what it will not do before they discover it on a jobsite. Ban game changer language from the pitch.

MARK FLY · PRODUCT EVANGELIST AND CONSTRUCTION TECH ADVISOR · [HEAR IT AT 20:49 →](#)

## The GC that can bid its CM fee at zero wins, because the margin lives in supply, insurance, and equipment.

Victor Muchiri, a former project engineer at Barton Malow and Turner who later served as Barton Malow's Entrepreneur in Residence, watched fee compression push contractors into self perform, CSIPs, SDI insurance, prefab, and procurement. Turner is the endgame: SourceBlue for procurement, an insurance brokerage, and the newly announced FEC equipment rental business mean it soon will not matter what Turner earns on the CM fee. Walk into a bid meeting against that model and your 3 percent, knocked down to two and a half, still loses to a fee of zero that gets made up on everything else on the back end. His warning is that GCs stuck in no man's land, doing a little of everything, will fail.

"How do you go into a meeting against a Turner? They'll just do it for zero because you're going to make it up on everything else on the back end."

VICTOR MUCHIRI · 50:18

**THE MOVE** Decide deliberately what business your GC is in, then build the ancillary lines where the margin actually lives, supply, insurance, equipment, self perform, instead of defending a compressed CM fee with a little of everything.

VICTOR MUCHIRI · GROWTH LEAD, BUILD VISION · [HEAR IT AT 50:18 →](#)

## **Sell construction tech like porta potties: show up on one project with donuts, demo, close it on site, drive to the next.**

Tech is not spec'd into the project any more than porta potties are. Chasing enterprise agreements without enterprise features is how startups stall.

KP REDDY · MANAGING PARTNER, SHADOW VENTURES · [HEAR IT →](#)



## Put field practitioners on your advisory board, not just VPs, or you will build for the person who signs and not the one who uses.

Back in the SmartBid days, somewhere between the first 100 and 300 customers, Mark Fly's company built an advisory board, and he had watched every other contech company stack theirs with VPs, big names, and the people who sign the checks. Mark was adamant the board be real contractors instead, people in the muck who walk sites and run bids daily, and he pushed to seat practitioners like Lars and Seth Cheever. His reasoning is that the field practitioners are the ones who detect BS, while the 30th floor view builds a product for the person who signs rather than the person who uses. He gives the same advice to funded startups today: really talk to your customers about their actual pains before building the flashy campaign.

"They normally go after the VPs and the big check writers. And I was adamant, adamant, no. We want real contractors on our advisory board."

MARK FLY · 22:45

**THE MOVE** Seat working supers, foremen, and estimators on your advisory board alongside any executives, and run product and roadmap decisions past the people who would use the tool every day.

MARK FLY · PRODUCT EVANGELIST AND CONSTRUCTION TECH ADVISOR · [HEAR IT AT 22:45 →](#)

## **Prefab is a manufacturing business, not construction in a warehouse, and running it with a construction mindset is how you get burned.**

Andrew Rener helped run Centerline Prefab and admits he started without an appreciation for the gap between running a manufacturing business and doing construction in a warehouse. Manufacturing demands documented processes, work instructions, and controlled environments that field habits do not supply, a full paradigm shift from how construction teams operate. When COVID stopped travel, he enrolled in his alma mater's remote graduate courses specifically to learn manufacturing processes, a path that grew into a full engineering doctorate. He is equally blunt on the sales side: prefab loses line item cost comparisons and only wins when owners value the holistic case, schedule compression and certainty of outcome.

"I didn't personally have an appreciation for the difference between running that business as a manufacturing business versus construction in a warehouse."

ANDREW RENER · 3:30

**THE MOVE** Run a prefab operation as a factory from day one: documented manufacturing processes, work instructions, and controlled environment quality control, staffed with manufacturing expertise rather than transplanted field habits.

ANDREW RENER · EXECUTIVE, ARCHITECTURAL METALS ·

[\*\*HEAR IT AT 3:30 →\*\*](#)